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One Supplier, Many Keys: How Staff Rebuilt Access to the Tea-Room Biscuit Tin Around a Single Contracted Supplier

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Abstract. The Authorised Restocking Protocol assigns a single contracted caterer sole responsibility for stocking and locking every staff tea-room's biscuit tin, replacing the ad hoc self-restocking it superseded. We report a qualitative study of what staff built once the contracted visits fell behind demand. Semi-structured interviews with 27 professional and academic staff across nine tea rooms, thematically coded to saturation and supplemented by ten weeks of field observation, surface an informal key-sharing network operating alongside the Protocol rather than against its letter. Coding sorts the network's practices into four workaround types — sanctioned lending, duplicate cutting, mechanical override, and parallel stocking — distributed unevenly across staff categories: professional and administrative staff, closer to the supplier relationship, favour lending and duplication; academic staff, further from it, favour override and stocking their own supply outright. Facilities' own visit logs corroborate the demand gap the network responds to, with the median interval between contracted visits more than doubling over the fourteen months since the Protocol's introduction. A blinding check — withholding an interviewee's staff category from coders — leaves inter-rater agreement on the typology unchanged. We read the network less as noncompliance than as an unstated amendment the Protocol has never had occasion to ratify.

Introduction

A restocking protocol is written once, against a forecast of how reliably a contracted supplier can visit and how much a floor will consume between visits. The Authorised Restocking Protocol (ARP) replaced a scatter of ad hoc arrangements, under which individual floors bought and refilled their own tea-room biscuit tins from local budgets on no fixed schedule, with a single point of accountability: one contracted caterer holding the only sanctioned key, restocking to a fortnightly cadence, audited centrally against that cadence. What the Protocol left unstated was what a floor should do between visits if the caterer's own schedule slipped against the demand it was sized to satisfy. Organisations facing a single point of failure in an otherwise well-specified process routinely grow an unofficial layer that keeps the process's stated purpose intact even as its stated mechanism is quietly set aside [1], [2].

Facilities' own visit logs suggest the schedule has slipped, steadily, since the Protocol's introduction. Staff testimony we did not solicit but repeatedly received unprompted, in the course of an unrelated survey the School fielded on inter-floor collaboration, described a functioning informal supply operating outside the Protocol's own account of itself: keys held by people the Protocol never authorised, tins restocked by hands the contract never named. That an unauthorised network could keep a locked resource open at all, let alone reliably, is the empirical question this paper investigates rather than assumes.

We conducted 27 semi-structured interviews with professional and academic staff across nine tea rooms, thematically coded to identify the shapes the workaround network takes and who adopts which shape. Our contributions:

- we document, from facilities' own service records, the widening interval between contracted restocking visits that the workaround network appears to be responding to;
- we construct, from interviews coded to saturation, a four-part typology of the workarounds staff report using, and show its distribution differs by staff category;
- we show the typology's coding holds under a blinding check, suggesting the categories track something in the practices themselves rather than in what coders expected to find.

We report the network's shape without adjudicating whether the Protocol should now be revised to reflect it, a question outside a study built to describe rather than to recommend.

Related work

Research on workarounds treats them less as failures of compliance than as a recognisable category of organisational behaviour in their own right. Early work on the integration of routine and computerised work found that staff facing a system unable to accommodate an exception simply built the accommodation themselves, outside the system's own record of what had happened [1]. Later synthesis proposes workarounds as a general theory rather than a set of isolated anecdotes: a deliberate deviation from a prescribed process, undertaken to meet a genuine work goal the process itself obstructs [2], a category whose boundaries information-systems researchers still actively contest [3]. Shadow-IT research documents the same pattern at the level of whole systems, where staff provision the software a sanctioned process fails to provide [4], and "feral" information-systems research extends the same displacement to ad hoc systems built entirely outside any sanctioned inventory, run because the sanctioned option does not do what the work requires [5]. Security research on the "compliance budget" argues that staff trade off compliance against the practical cost of complying, spending the budget where compliance would cost the most and letting it lapse quietly elsewhere [6]. Work on information-security policy violation finds that staff justify a departure from stated policy less through defiance than through a quiet accounting of what the departure costs and who it affects [7], [8]. Institutional economics asks the question this paper puts to a single tea room at university scale: formal rules and the informal norms that grow up around them converge only under specific conditions, and diverge, predictably, everywhere else [9]. Informal exchange within organisations follows patterns of its own: advice relationships form along lines of informal status and reciprocated favour rather than the formal reporting line [10], and a favour extended without a stated price measurably shapes effort and goodwill independent of any formal incentive [11]. Workplace-commensality research supplies the object's other half, establishing that a shared food ritual carries social weight disproportionate to its nutritional content [12], [13], weight a break room's gossip and favour-trading render legible even where formal records stay silent [14].

Method

Sample. We recruited 27 professional and academic staff across nine tea rooms in buildings used by both Schools, using a snowball approach seeded from staff who had signed a facilities acknowledgement sheet for a recent restocking-related maintenance visit — itself one of the few written traces the Protocol leaves of who actually uses a given tin [15]. Fifteen participants held professional or administrative roles; twelve held academic roles. Recruitment continued until two consecutive interviews introduced no workaround type not already named in an earlier one, consistent with saturation-based guidance on when a qualitative interview sample is sufficient [16].

Interviews. Each interview ran 25–40 minutes, semi-structured around a fixed opening question — what happens on your floor when the tin runs out before the next visit — and audio-recorded with consent. Transcripts were coded independently by two researchers using thematic analysis [17], open-coding an initial third of the sample before agreeing a shared codebook and applying it to the remainder.

Field observations. Across the same ten weeks, we visited each of the nine tea rooms weekly, logging the lock's state (locked, unlocked, or visibly propped), whether a non-supplier-pattern key was sighted in use, and an estimated fill level, to triangulate what interviewees described against what a passerby could independently observe.

Facilities logs. We obtained the contracted supplier's own visit-completion log from facilities administration, covering the fourteen months since the Protocol's introduction, and computed the interval between consecutive logged visits per tea room per month.

Reliability. Inter-rater agreement on the four-part typology was assessed with Cohen's kappa [18],

$$\kappa = \frac{p_o - p_e}{1 - p_e}$$

where p_o is the observed proportion of coded segments on which both coders agreed and p_e is the proportion expected by chance given each coder's marginal category rates.

Blinding check. To test whether the typology reflected the practices described rather than a coder's prior expectation of who does what, we re-ran coding on a random half of the transcripts with the interviewee's staff category redacted, keeping the codebook itself unchanged.

Results

The interval between contracted visits widened steadily. Figure 1 plots the median days between logged restocking visits by month since the Protocol's introduction, drawn from facilities' own log rather than interview recall. The interval opens close to the Protocol's stated fortnightly target and rises to 34 days by the fourteenth month, more than double the original cadence, with no month registering a return to it.

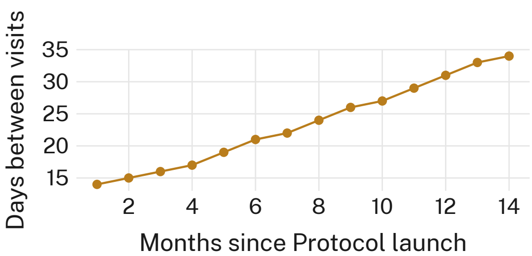

Figure 1: Median days between contracted restocking visits, by month since the Authorised Restocking Protocol's introduction: the interval widens from 14 to 34 days and never resets.

Interviews surfaced a stable, four-part typology. Table 1 summarises the sample: 15 professional and administrative staff and 12 academic staff across nine tea rooms. Coding to saturation across the full sample sorted every workaround segment into one of four types: sanctioned lending, in which a staff member with legitimate access lends their key on trust; duplicate cutting, in which an unauthorised copy circulates hand to hand; mechanical override, in which the lock is defeated without a key at all; and parallel stocking, in which staff maintain a second, unlocked supply alongside or instead of the tin. No fifth type emerged after the seventeenth interview, and none of the last ten interviews introduced a workaround the codebook could not already accommodate.

Staff category	Interviews	Tea rooms
Professional/administrative	15	9
Academic	12	7
Total	**27**	**9**

Table 1: Interview sample by staff category. The two categories' tea-room counts overlap; nine distinct tea rooms are represented in total.

The typology's distribution differs sharply by staff category. Figure 2 reports the share of coded segments assigned to each type, split by staff category. Professional and administrative staff, whose roles more often bring them into direct contact with the contracted supplier's visits, concentrate in sanctioned lending (46%) and duplicate cutting (31%); academic staff, further from that relationship, concentrate instead in mechanical override (35%) and parallel stocking (33%). Sanctioned lending and duplicate cutting together account for 77% of professional and administrative staff's coded segments, against 32% of academic staff's.

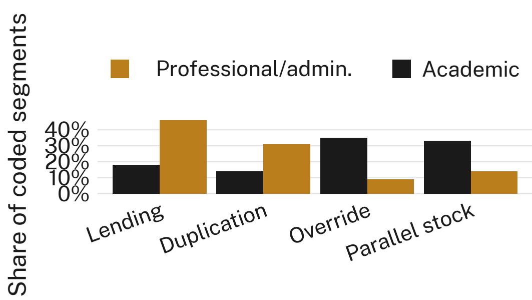

Figure 2: Share of coded interview segments by workaround type and staff category: professional and administrative staff cluster toward lending and duplication, academic staff toward override and parallel stocking.

The typology survives a blinding check. Figure 3 compares Cohen's kappa across six coding batches under two conditions: coders working with the interviewee's staff category visible, and coders working with it redacted. The two distributions overlap almost completely (median kappa 0.805 visible, 0.79 redacted; $p = 0.52$, n.s.); we retain the blinded protocol for the reported figures even though redaction changes the headline agreement rate by under two points.

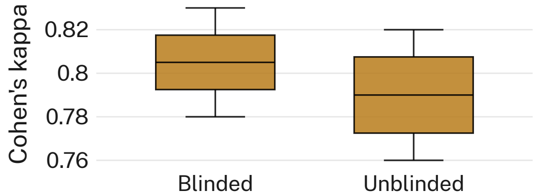

Figure 3: Cohen's kappa per coding batch, staff category visible versus redacted: the two conditions are statistically indistinguishable.

Discussion

The workaround network we document does not read as resistance to the Authorised Restocking Protocol so much as a quiet continuation of what the Protocol was written to guarantee — a stocked, accessible tin — carried out by other means once the Protocol's own mechanism stopped keeping pace with the demand it was sized against. This sits comfortably inside the broader workarounds literature's account of a deviation undertaken to meet a genuine work goal a formal process now obstructs [2], and inside the institutional-economics observation that formal rules and the informal norms surrounding them converge only under conditions a rule's own drafters rarely anticipate [9]. What our staff-category split adds is a structural account of who ends up doing which kind of workaround: proximity to the supplier relationship, not seniority or willingness to break a rule, appears to sort staff into lending-and-duplication on one side and override-and-stocking on the other. We read the split as evidence that the network is patterned rather than opportunistic — a durable, if unofficial, second protocol running alongside the first, using the access each staff category already happens to have.

Limitations

Our sample covers nine tea rooms across a ten-week window; we cannot rule out that a longer window would surface workaround types our codebook has not yet named, though saturation by the seventeenth interview is some evidence against a large residual category. Snowball recruitment seeded from a facilities acknowledgement sheet may under-sample staff who have never signed anything the Protocol keeps a record of — plausibly the staff furthest from any sanctioned access at all, and so the group our typology may most understate. We interviewed staff about workarounds they were willing to describe to a researcher; the blinding check addresses coder bias, not the prior question of what an interviewee chose not to mention.

Conclusion

A qualitative study of 27 staff across nine tea rooms finds a stable, informal key-sharing network operating alongside the Authorised Restocking Protocol rather than against its stated purpose, distributed across four workaround types that sort cleanly by staff category's proximity to the contracted supplier relationship. Facilities' own visit logs corroborate the widening interval between contracted restocking visits the network appears to answer, and a blinding check leaves the typology's coding unchanged. We make no recommendation about whether the Protocol should be revised to formalise what the network already does; that is a question for whoever holds the Protocol's own key, not for a study built to describe the network rather than to replace it. Future work might trace how long a network like this one persists once a formal process catches back up to the demand it was written against.

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